Classroom transitions

Moving smoothly between learning activities

Use a taught transition to move students from one activity to the next without losing attention or learning time. Specify how to stop, shift resources and begin the new demand.

How to do it well

1 Teach it before using it. Name the transition, explain why it matters, model an example and non-example, and rehearse the sequence with feedback.

2 Precorrect immediately before the moment. Remind pupils what will stop, move, remain in place and begin; keep the cue brief and positive.

3 Reinforce the exact success. Describe the efficient, calm behaviour worth repeating rather than offering generic praise.

4 Actively supervise. Stay visible and mobile, scan likely breakdown points and avoid using transition time for administration.

5 Revisit and reteach. Refresh after holidays, timetable changes, new pupils or early signs of routine drift; distinguish an unlearned skill from inconsistent performance.

What this sounds like

“In ten seconds, stop the discussion. Keep the chairs where they are, face the board and wait for the next instruction.”

Classroom example. A Product Design transition moves pupils from drawing to collecting materials. The teacher primes the stop, gives one resource action at a time and rehearses the route beforehand. Students know where to place unfinished work and when to start again. Practical logistics do not compete with the explanation of the next learning task.

Top tips that make the technique work

Teach the transition as content. Model and rehearse the exact sequence before relying on it.

Prime the stopping point. Warn students what will happen and what their first next action will be.

Reduce simultaneous demands. Equipment movement, instructions and new subject content should not all compete at once.

Diagnose the failure. Students may not know the routine, or may know it but not yet perform it fluently.

Rehearse the troublesome component. A brief practice of resource return or partner rotation can solve more than a general reminder.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Use clear stop and start cues.	Assuming the routine is obvious.
Protect the first moments of the new task.	Giving new academic instructions while equipment is moving.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

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